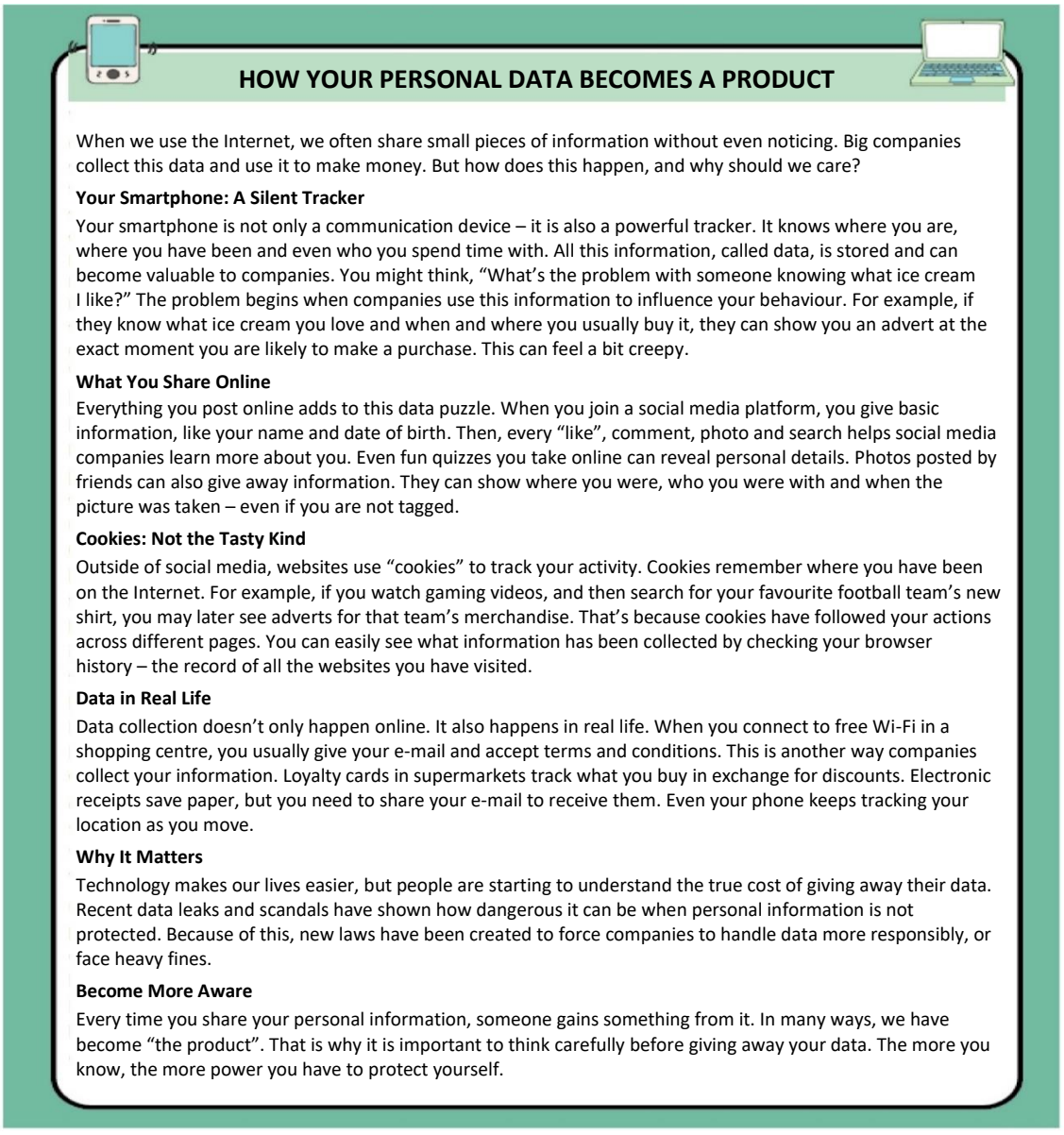
B2 - Written Mediation 4: Learning Sequence

Personal Data on the Net

Your German friend Klaus has an 11-year-old brother, Ben. You met Ben when you were on a school exchange in Germany. He has been given his first smartphone, and he is excited about sharing photographs on social media. Klaus would like Ben to use his phone sensibly. You read this article in a magazine, and you think some of the ideas would be useful to help him. Write an e-mail to Klaus explaining the most relevant points. (80-100 words)



HOW YOUR PERSONAL DATA BECOMES A PRODUCT

When we use the Internet, we often share small pieces of information without even noticing. Big companies collect this data and use it to make money. But how does this happen, and why should we care?

Your Smartphone: A Silent Tracker

Your smartphone is not only a communication device – it is also a powerful tracker. It knows where you are, where you have been and even who you spend time with. All this information, called data, is stored and can become valuable to companies. You might think, "What's the problem with someone knowing what ice cream I like?" The problem begins when companies use this information to influence your behaviour. For example, if they know what ice cream you love and when and where you usually buy it, they can show you an advert at the exact moment you are likely to make a purchase. This can feel a bit creepy.

What You Share Online

Everything you post online adds to this data puzzle. When you join a social media platform, you give basic information, like your name and date of birth. Then, every "like", comment, photo and search helps social media companies learn more about you. Even fun quizzes you take online can reveal personal details. Photos posted by friends can also give away information. They can show where you were, who you were with and when the picture was taken – even if you are not tagged.

Cookies: Not the Tasty Kind

Outside of social media, websites use "cookies" to track your activity. Cookies remember where you have been on the Internet. For example, if you watch gaming videos, and then search for your favourite football team's new shirt, you may later see adverts for that team's merchandise. That's because cookies have followed your actions across different pages. You can easily see what information has been collected by checking your browser history – the record of all the websites you have visited.

Data in Real Life

Data collection doesn't only happen online. It also happens in real life. When you connect to free Wi-Fi in a shopping centre, you usually give your e-mail and accept terms and conditions. This is another way companies collect your information. Loyalty cards in supermarkets track what you buy in exchange for discounts. Electronic receipts save paper, but you need to share your e-mail to receive them. Even your phone keeps tracking your location as you move.

Why It Matters

Technology makes our lives easier, but people are starting to understand the true cost of giving away their data. Recent data leaks and scandals have shown how dangerous it can be when personal information is not protected. Because of this, new laws have been created to force companies to handle data more responsibly, or face heavy fines.

Become More Aware

Every time you share your personal information, someone gains something from it. In many ways, we have become "the product". That is why it is important to think carefully before giving away your data. The more you know, the more power you have to protect yourself.

In written mediation, you need to interpret the content of the article and be able to explain the information in it in an informal or colloquial way.

Refer to the document you have been asked to read. But do not copy it. Paraphrase the ideas there.



Let's get ready!

1. Analyse the task

Read the task carefully and say whether these statements are true (T) or false (F). They will help you choose the register of the mediation task.

a) Ben is 11 years old and has just received his first smartphone. _____

b) Klaus wants Ben to use his phone carefully and sensibly. _____

c) You met Ben during a holiday trip to Germany. _____

d) The task asks you to write an e-mail giving advice to Ben about using social media safely. _____

2. Analyse the information

Read the information in the article carefully.

a) Make a list of things you have to include in your e-mail in the first column. You can copy the words from the article.

b) In the second column, paraphrase the list. Use your own words to refer to the same ideas. Do not write whole sentences. Just the idea behind each thing.

Things to include	Use your own words

Read the article again and say whether these sentences are true or false according to the article:

a) Social media platforms only collect the information you give them when you create an account.

_____

b) Cookies can track what you do on different websites and show you adverts based on your searches.

_____

c) Free Wi-Fi in public places does not collect any personal information from users.

_____

d) Loyalty cards in supermarkets collect data about what customers buy in exchange for discounts.

_____

Let's prepare the language!

1. An informal e-mail

Read the e-mail below where a student is explaining to her friend about something annoying that happened to her.

Subject: Something annoying happened ☹ Hi Sarah, OMG, you won't believe what happened! Someone sent me a mean message on my phone today ☹. I didn't reply, but it really upset me. I told my big brother, and he said not to worry and to block the person. I'm glad he helped me. Have you ever had something like this happen? Talk soon, Emma

Read the e-mail again and find examples of:

a) Contractions (short forms of words) → _____

b) Informal language / slang / emojis → _____

c) Short sentences / casual style → _____

d) Punctuation for emotion → _____

e) Friendly opening and closing → _____

2. Polite suggestions and recommendations

Remember	
Simple suggestion	We could (verb) ... . / How about (verb + *-ing*)?
Strong / Direct recommendation	You should / must (verb) ... . / I highly recommend (verb + *-ing* / noun).
Advice / Gentle suggestion	Have you considered (verb + *-ing*)? / It might be a good idea to (verb) ... .
Hypothetical suggestion (Less direct)	If I were you, I'd (verb) ... . / You could always try (verb) ... .
Suggestion clause	I suggest that you (verb base form) ... . / I recommend that we (verb base form) ... .

A. Imagine your team is struggling to finish a project on time. You need suggestions for improving collaboration, managing time better and reducing stress among the members. Write down three suggestions and recommendations using different structures.

_____

_____

_____

B. Read the example e-mail below. Underline all the polite suggestions and recommendations.

Hi Alex,

I heard you've been having trouble finishing your homework because of your phone. You should try putting your phone in another room while studying. You could set a timer for each homework session to stay focused. It's also a good idea to take short breaks so you don't get too tired.

Hope this helps!

Best,

Holmes

In the e-mail above, Holmes is writing to Alex, who is distracted by his / her phone and not finishing their homework. Why is Holmes writing the e-mails below?

Hi Jamie,

Before posting your video, you should think about who will see it and how they might feel. You could ask a friend or family member for their opinion first. It's a good idea to check if the content is safe and doesn't share personal information.

Good luck!

Cheers,

Holmes

Scenario: _____

Hi Sam,

I think your little brother should be careful about what he shares online. You could show him how to use privacy settings to stay safe. It's also a good idea to explain why personal info, like his address or school, should stay private.

Take care,

Holmes

Scenario: _____

Hi Taylor,

I'm sorry you got that message. You shouldn't reply to it because it might make things worse. You could block the person and tell a trusted adult what happened. It's also a good idea to save the message as evidence, just in case.

Hope this helps!

Best wishes,

Holmes

Scenario: _____

Do not use the same expressions to suggest or recommend an action all the time. It is important to vary the language to show you have a good vocabulary.



Let's mediate!

Your German friend Klaus has an 11-year-old brother, Ben. You met Ben when you were on a school exchange in Germany. He has been given his first smartphone, and he is excited about sharing photographs on social media. Klaus would like Ben to use his phone sensibly. You read this article in a magazine, and you think some of the ideas would be useful to help him. Write an e-mail to Klaus explaining the most relevant points. (80-100 words)

1. Content

Content

Look at the instructions and the article, and read the information there carefully again. Select the information you are going to tell your friend. You can use the following questions:

- How do mobile phones follow us?
- Why is it important to use our mobile phone sensibly?
- Which tips can you give your friend? Be as specific as possible.

2. Language

Language

Use your own words. Simplify or paraphrase the information.

Remember to adapt your language (register, style) to the task and addressee.

Vary the language you use. Look at the useful language on pages 2, 3 and 4.